

By the 18th century, the workshop tradition in Europe was being replaced by academies that excluded women from classes and denied them access to the prestigious commissions of the day. Despite this, some female artists achieved success in genres such as portraiture, among them Elizabeth Louise Vigée Le Brun.

In the 19th century, the new medium of photography attracted women as it lacked the restrictions on training and practice that had held women back in painting and sculpture. British portrait photographer Julia Margaret Cameron and influential US photographer Gertrude Käsebier were pioneers of the form.

Women also began to emerge as prominent members of artists' groups which are more commonly associated with men. Mary Cassatt and Berthe Morisot, for example, were leading members of the Impressionist movement in France. In early 20th-century Russia, where the Revolution placed equal emphasis on the training of women and men, artists such as Lyubov Popova and Alexandra Exter were key exponents of Russian Constructivism.

Modernism and beyond

Although growing numbers of female artists achieved success, others continued to be overshadowed by husbands or male colleagues. Lee Krasner, wife of Jackson Pollock, and Joan Mitchell were leading artists of Abstract Expressionism, but never attained the same level of commercial success as Pollock or their friend Willem de Kooning.

In the second half of the 20th century the feminist art movement emerged. North American artists, such as Joyce Wieland and Judy Chicago, incorporated knitting, ceramics, and needlework into their oeuvre. Today, feminist art, which has moved away from the male-dominated genres of painting and sculpture to embrace new media—performance art, installation, and video—has been credited with influencing contemporary art worldwide.

PROFILES

NOTABLE CREATORS

Artemisia Gentileschi (1593-1652/3) trained first in her father's workshop in Rome, then with landscape painter Agostino Tassi. He raped her, leading to a trial that came to overshadow her artistic achievements. Gentileschi's dramatic, Baroque-style paintings depicted women in biblical and literary scenes. In 1616, she became the first female member of Florence's Academy of Design.

Berthe Morisot (1841-1895) was a leading member of the French Impressionists. Her output focused on women's domestic lives. In 1867, she met Édouard Manet, becoming his friend and model. In 1874, she had nine works of her own in the first Impressionist exhibition. She showed with the group for the next 12 years.

Georgia O'Keeffe (1887-1986) trained at the Art Institute of Chicago and the Art Students League in New York. In 1916, she met gallerist Alfred Stieglitz, who put on her first solo show in 1917. They married in 1924, and from 1929 she worked in New Mexico. Focusing on flowers and landscapes, O'Keeffe used simplified forms and close-ups as routes to abstraction.

Louise Bourgeois (1911-2010) was born in Paris, but moved to New York in 1938 and attended the Art Students League. From her sculptures of the late 1940s to the giant spider sculptures that marked her final years, her work drew on her past and childhood.

Yayoi Kusama (b.1929) studied traditional Japanese painting in Kyoto. In 1958, she moved to New York, becoming known for her avant-garde *Happenings*, but returned to Japan in 1973. Embracing painting, performance, and fashion, her works include giant pumpkin sculptures and immersive installations.

Cindy Sherman (b.1954) graduated from college in Buffalo and moved to New York City in 1977. She became famous for photographic series such as *Untitled Film Stills* (1977-1980) and *History Portraits* (1989-1990), challenging the images of women presented in popular culture.